



United States
Attorney's Office
Eastern District of Pennsylvania



Philadelphia Man Sentenced to Over Two Years in Prison for Defrauding the Government of More Than \$1 Million in SNAP, Medicaid Benefits



Wednesday, August 20, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, Eastern District of
Pennsylvania

PHILADELPHIA – United States Attorney David Metcalf announced that James Sessoms, 60, of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, was sentenced today by United States District Judge Chad F. Kenney to 28 months in prison, three years of supervised release, and \$398,708.58 in restitution, for his scheme to use stolen identities and Social Security numbers (SSNs) to file for government benefits, including Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) and Medicaid payments, with a total loss to the government of \$1,063,633. As part of the scheme, the defendant would sell the fraudulently acquired SNAP cards for profit at a local supermarket.

Sessoms was charged by indictment in October of 2024 and pleaded guilty this April to one count of SNAP fraud, seven counts of false statements in connection with health care benefits, and seven counts of Social Security fraud.

As detailed in court filings and admitted to by the defendant, from approximately November 2019 through November 2023, Sessoms defrauded the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) of SNAP benefits, and the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) and Pennsylvania Department of Human Services (PA DHS) of Medicaid benefits, by submitting false and fraudulent benefit applications, including false and fraudulent identification documents in connection with his applications.

As part of the scheme, Sessoms obtained or created the names, SSNs, and personally identifiable information for several fictitious persons, and obtained the names and personally identifiable information of other persons, including valid SSNs, which he placed on the applications for SNAP and Medical benefits, which were submitted to PA DHS under penalty of perjury. To obtain these benefits,

Sessoms also submitted false and fraudulent driver's licenses bearing his photograph under those fictitious and other persons' names.

On some of the online applications, the defendant added purported family members, such as a spouse and children, which caused for more funds to be awarded for SNAP benefits, but also caused additional Medicaid costs, including additional costs for all of the added family members. To obtain these benefits with family members on the applications, Sessoms submitted fraudulent names and personally identifiable information for a spouse and children, to include fraudulent birth certificates for the children. The Social Security numbers utilized in connection with these identities were valid SSNs, assigned by the Commissioner of Social Security, but assigned to other individuals than the names alleged by the defendant.

From approximately November 2019 to November 2023, PA DHS, with joint federal funding from HHS, provided Medicaid coverage to Sessoms under his numerous aliases, as well as to his purported family members as he indicated on his fraudulent applications.

Over the same time period, PA DHS, with federal funding from the USDA, provided SNAP benefits to Sessoms under his numerous aliases, as well as to his purported family members as he indicated on his fraudulent applications.

"Stealing money from government programs is an awful crime," said U.S. Attorney Metcalf. "We will continue to prosecute fraud against the government and hold crooks like Sessoms accountable, on behalf of all the taxpayers funding these programs."

"We appreciate the collaboration with our law enforcement partners for their hard work on this investigation. Those who are involved in fraud regarding USDA taxpayer-funded programs will be investigated by our office to protect the integrity of those programs," said USDA Office of Inspector General (USDA-OIG) Special Agent in Charge Charmeka Parker.

"Mr. Sessoms orchestrated an audacious scheme—creating fake Social Security numbers while exploiting real ones—to siphon off more than \$1 million from programs meant to safeguard the most vulnerable," said Michelle L. Anderson, Acting Inspector General, Social Security Administration. "Let this case serve as a warning; those who exploit taxpayer-funded programs will be met with aggressive investigation and prosecution."

The case was investigated by the USDA-OIG, Social Security Administration Office of Inspector General, HHS Office of Inspector General, Homeland Security Investigations, and the Pennsylvania Office of State Inspector General and is being prosecuted by Special Assistant United States Attorney Megan Curran.

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